

however, can assign new account permissions based on the role the user will perform.

Roles and permissions: The roles define the amount of control a user has on moderation of discussions and over other users. At the very minimum, the users will be able to view their own profiles. At the other end of the spectrum is the administrator, who has full control over users, themes, moderation, categories management and spam control.

Registration: Many modes of registration are supported. The basic method lets the users choose a username and password, and requires them to enter CAPTCHA words for sign-up. The CAPTCHA security check should be configured by using the Google service. Another interesting registration process is 'registration through invitation'—the same way Gmail became popular, through invitation emails for new users to join.

Moderation: The forum gives you many options to control spam and posts as well as create ban lists.

Discussion categories: Categories, like directories on a file system, separate topics of discussion, and let users focus on discussions they prefer.

Flood control: This feature moderates the rate of posts to avoid some users hogging the discussion (or, in Internet use, automated posts).

Archive discussions: Based on the volume of posts, administrators can choose to archive older posts by date. This helps to reduce the clutter on the home page.

Tagging: The author of a discussion can create tags for easy search. Tagging is a non-hierarchical way of grouping discussions. More than one tag can be assigned to a discussion. For example, a post on the 'SRK controversy at Mumbai stadium' can have the tags of 'cricket', 'ipl', 'bollywood' and 'mumbai'.

Plug-ins

Version 2.0.18.4 of Vanilla comes with 16 plug-ins as part of the software bundle. The plug-ins include integration with Internet communities like Facebook, Google, OpenID and Twitter; and have value-add features like a WYSIWYG editor, statistics, etc. In addition, the administrator can select plug-ins from a repository of hundreds of them at vanillaforums.org.

Promoting adoption

Setting up the forum is the easiest part; the real challenge is to get people to use it. Web 2.0 collaboration sites like blogs, wikis and discussion forums thrive on the 'network effect'; the more people that join, the higher is the value to all. So here are some tips to promote the forum, which will be useful in the early days after the launch.

1. Analyse the purpose of forming the discussion group

Identify the main purpose of the discussion group. Is it to

discuss ideas on innovation or for discussing anything under the sun? Though the group could later change the scope of the discussion forum, provide a clear objective.

2. Identify popular categories

Create high-level categories that are of interest to the group the forum caters to. At least have a few initial threads of discussion that allow new users to participate.

3. Identify the influencers

It takes a few highly motivated influencers to get started with such endeavours. Identify them, and ask them to share their valuable thoughts through this means. Paradoxically, most talented people may not be the best writers, and the best writers may not be the most talented! The challenge is to identify the right mix for your discussion forum.

4. Focus on content first, then the number of users

Never make the mistake of advertising the discussion forum to all as soon as it's launched. New users visit the place, see the empty forum, and may never return. First focus on having engaging discussion threads. Then, preferably, use the option of 'registration by invitation', so that news about the discussion forum spreads by word of mouth.

5. Have patience

It could take weeks or months for people to visit and evaluate the discussions. The Vanilla statistics feature will give you an indication of the level of activity, so that you can measure the traction. When you feel that interaction levels have come down, introduce a new plug-in, and advertise it on the main page using the 'Message' option.

6. Remember to back up periodically

The biggest lesson I have learnt from hard experience is to have periodic (daily or weekly) back-ups of the discussion database.

Setting up and promoting a discussion forum using Vanilla is fun, and worth the time spent. It could become the most happening thing in your organisation. 

References

- [1] Vanilla Home (<http://vanillaforums.com>)
- [2] Hundredth Monkey Effect (http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hundredth_monkey_effect)

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